all. I had already missed days and months of my children's childhood. Now I was finally at home with them all day but was unable to play with them.

Once I'd got over the journey, I started the recovery process under the aegis of Paul Close and Paul Chapman. I did not go out for three weeks during rehab, as I was so tired from all my training, which would start at seven in the morning. I spent the second week of my rehab at the National Cricket Academy, and my training included strengthening exercises, cardio, pool sessions, running – both straight and sideways – specialized exercises with the Thera-Band, and a number of other drills. It would end at around two thirty in the afternoon, following which I would just go home, have lunch and sleep for a few hours, completely exhausted.

The target I had set myself was to recover for the Test series against Australia that started in Bangalore at the beginning of October 2008. I knew it would be a race against time and I had a lot of hard work ahead of me. There were days when I would push myself so hard that by the evening I would just collapse on the bed and had no strength left, then I would get up very early the next morning and start my exercises all over again. Throughout this period, my group of friends, including Atul Ranade, Sameer Dighe and Jagdish Chavan, were always there to motivate me and would train with me all day. Their presence was a great help and I remain ever indebted to them for their support.

Australia in India, October–November 2008

It was a great relief to be back on the field for the first Test against Australia in Bangalore on 9 October. Australia made 430 in their first innings, with Ponting and Hussey both making hundreds, and we made 360 in reply. I scored only 13 in my first innings, but did better in the second innings before falling to the leg-spin of Cameron White. I scored 49 but, more importantly, I was able to bat for close to three hours and faced more than a hundred balls without feeling discomfort. The match was drawn and we headed to Mohali for the second of the four Tests.

The series had assumed greater significance because Sourav had announced that he would be retiring at the end of the fourth Test at Nagpur. Sourav and I always had a great rapport and we shared a lot of great moments together. As teenagers, we both spent a month at an